the unreliable self
a reader

COMBO edition

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BIOS

Renee Gladman is a writer and artist preoccupied with crossings, thresholds, and geographies as they play out at the intersections of poetry, prose, drawing and architecture. She is the author of fourteen published works, including a cycle of novels about the city-state Ravicka and its inhabitants, the Ravickians—Event Factory (2010), The Ravickians (2011), Ana Patova Crosses a Bridge (2013) and Houses of Ravicka (2017)—as well as three collections of drawings: Prose Architectures (2017), One Long Black Sentence, a series of white ink drawings on black paper, indexed by Fred Moten (2020), and Plans for Sentences (2022). Recent essays and visual work have appeared in POETRY Magazine, The Paris Review, Gulf Coast, Granta, Harper's, BOMB magazine, e-flux and n+1. She has been awarded fellowships, artist grants, and residencies from the Radcliffe Institute for Advanced Study at Harvard, Foundation for Contemporary Arts, the Lannan Foundation, and KW Institute for Contemporary Art (Berlin), and is a 2021 Windham-Campbell Prize winner in fiction. She makes her home in New England with poet-ceremonialist Danielle Vogel.

Mia You was born in Seoul, South Korea, grew up in Northern California, and now lives in Utrecht, The Netherlands. Her first full-length collection is I, Too, Dislike It (1913 Press, 2016), which Rachel Levitsky calls, "a companion, an aria to bodily discomfort and impossibility." Lisa Robertson writes in The Brooklyn Rail, "That the gently derided 'small drama of my suburban-middle-class-Korean-American life / makes poetry' aligns You's documentary project with mentors such as Mayer, Rankine, and Hejinian, and younger contemporaries such as Susan Briante."
You's poems also have appeared as a chapbook, Objective Practice (Achiote Press, 2007), and an artist's book, YOU (created by Thorsten Kiefer, 2004). She currently teaches creative writing and literature at the Universiteit Utrecht, after completing a PhD in English at the University of California, Berkeley. She writes essays and book reviews and has published them with Artforum, Bookforum, The Critical Flame, The Hairpin, Jacket2, and the Los Angeles Review of Books.

Lucy Ives is the author of three novels: Impossible Views of the World, published by Penguin Press and selected as a New York Times Book Review Editors' Choice; Loudermilk: Or, The Real Poet; Or, The Origin of the World, published by Soft Skull Press and also a New York Times Book Review Editors' Choice; and Life Is Everywhere, published by Graywolf Press and a best book of 2022 with The New Yorker and the Seattle Times. A graduate of Harvard and the Iowa Writers' Workshop, she holds a Ph.D. in comparative literature from New York University. She is currently Bonderman Assistant Professor of the Practice in Literary Arts at Brown University and was a recipient of a 2018 Creative Capital | Andy Warhol Foundation Arts Writers Grant. Her book of essays, An Image of My Name Enters America, was recently released by Graywolf Press.

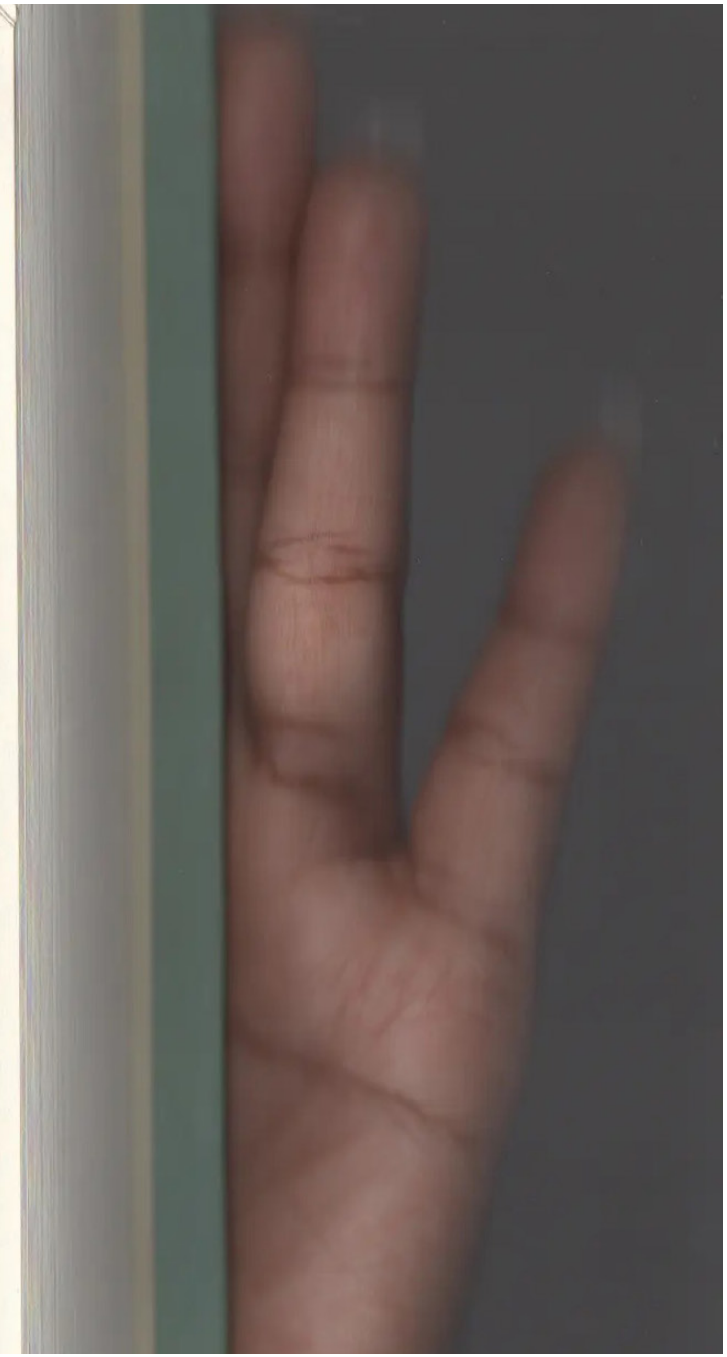
Dionne Brand is the author of numerous volumes of fiction, poetry, and nonfiction. Her latest poetry collection, Nomenclature: New and Collected Poems, won the Los Angeles Times Book Prize for Poetry. Her other collections have won the Griffin Poetry Prize, the Governor General's Literary Award, and the Trillium Book Award. Her works of nonfiction include Bread Out of Stone and A Map to the Door of No Return: Notes to Belonging. From 2009 to 2012 she served as Toronto's poet laureate, and in 2021 she was awarded a Windham-Campbell Prize for Fiction. She lives in Toronto and is the author of new nonfiction book Salvage: Readings from the Wreck.

Pia Louwerens (1990, Netherlands) holds a Bachelor of Fine Arts from the Royal Academy of Art in The Hague, and a laureate of a.pass (advanced performance and scenography studies): a post-master program for artistic research in Brussels. From 2019-2020, Pia was a researcher on an NWO-funded project in the Netherlands, on the basis of which she published the book 'I'm Not Sad, The World Is Sad' in 2021: an autotheoretical, semi-fictional novel about her work as an 'embedded' researcher at an art institution. In 2023, Pia researched "Lesbisch Archief Leeuwarden" (Lesbian Archives Leeuwarden) with Katinka van Gorkum at Kunsthuis SYB (Beeststerzwaag). Besides her art practice, Pia works as a freelance art critic for De Witte Raaf, Tubelight and Metropolis M, among others, and in 2023 as a transition manager for a.pass.

The Blue Clerk
by Dionne Brand

VERSO 5.0.1

What the author has. A line in her left cheek, a pain in her left shoulder, a crushed molar, an electric wire running from her elbow to her smallest left finger. Wings in her left eye.



source: www.are.na/za-george/the-blue-clerk

We Were Glowing Dark Inanimates
by Renee Gladman

And in all that time I was watching something still be still and something named be named inside a syntax that was the shape of a narrow channel; I was watching stillness itself sit in a defining stillness, in a radiant enactment of holding still and waiting, of being pinned and waiting, of being sculpted as something open and curved, something tapered and painted and stained and heated, something stripped and set to stillness, moving only when moved, still even when so, still even when. I was watching something be still even when moving and I saw a syntax try to carry it and felt space cut around it, and I saw the day unfold. I saw someone open the curtains, then close them. I saw someone pour a glass of something and drink it while pacing the light; it was another day of radiant inaction. It became a series of radiantly inactive days. You were being held inside and time had become something measured by something being drunk, and something pacing inside something solid and opaque, the wood of the house eroding but holding back the light and water of the outdoors, yet letting in the small animals, the varied insect life. And this was how still it was inside the narrow syntax that was the flow of something waiting being defined by its own curving, shaped by another, named by. It was in a holding pattern and was holding and being held by being named and was so still the day passed through it and light refracted off it and made shadows on the floor and on the back of the person waiting also, waiting to be named or renamed, waiting to mask or unmask, waiting to be safe or held, to breach the town, to cross the threshold of the door. Such that between the person and the stillness was a use not being tended to; each entity in that place had something it was becoming but also was still patterned by something it was leaving. You were never just new or just made; you came from something. I was a composite of elements and had been standing in front of the door for a long time, won-

read online: www.e-flux.com/journal/136/538552/we-were-glowing-dark-inanimates/

dering what was happening in the world and to the world, and behind me were several other shaped elements forged from elements not present, and we were all sitting in a kind of ink—written on but also capable of writing. I wanted to be someone who could build despite rarely going outside; I wanted things that were teeming with darkness lit from inside, bright from non-knowing, and for these things to hold space and cut space while buildings were going up and days were passing.

It was easy to turn around and see their stillness; it was impossible to catch them in motion. We were all expected to be in motion because that was how time moved and how success was measured: you were getting on an airplane, you were walking the streets of a city, you were meeting people in a bar, signing your name to things, you were racing through the night with your care and your use, presenting yourself to others, to another, everybody reading each other's quick views—this is how I work, this is what I do—then walking off together. There was a lot of movement inside of something not moving. Inside the body waiting for the world was something radiant and silent. It was elemental and pressured for action; it was something ancient with something teeming inside of it; it was something named next to something teeming; it was teeming slowed by being named and put to care. It was a rounded rough; it was a hard, flat extended: it was fired and cooled and left for a decade. It was dug up and scraped then fired. It was something hard and curving; it was something ancient and set to use and was inside you. Dark glowing memories. It was something glazed. It had a glaze that made what was moving inside it still; things were happening on the exterior side of being a dark animate glowing. You were set to roam sitting inside something set for use.

I picked up a ceramic cup and pulled from it until it was empty then replaced it. Everything was bright. I picked up a bowl; I picked up a wooden spoon and set it in the bowl; I placed the bowl and spoon onto a flat, smooth surface that stood twenty-nine inches above the floor then I sat down on something soft about eight inches below my bowl. I waited: someone was bringing something. Someone was cooking something to bring, so I waited with these ancient entities.

I was an ancient entity borrowed by space for time. Waiting here, glowing darkness.

I was waiting and time was unfolding, and I had a name that held me in place; I had my care and my use. I was something still sat inside something still, waiting for something hot. Someone was crossing the floor with something hot, and we were in a kind of choreography of objects revealing and suppressing their care and use. It was a strained and radiant inaction of elements fired and glazed into stillness but moving even so. It was a day of doing things with and next to objects that were fired and glazed, that were sanded and scraped and painted. Everything I picked up I also counted. Everything was clay; everything was iron. There were rims and handles all over the world, too many to count. Everything was glass: there were flutes and bubbles; there were cracks and sealant. Everything was marble. Things were slightly amethyst in color. Everything was wood; everything was ivory. Things had come through silver. Everything was bronze. It was a collection of pressures. Everything was cast; everything was set to mold, was curved and molded, and as the elements were bent to care something went quiet in everything. You couldn't have some parts of the space be quiet without other parts taking on quiet, too. You couldn't be animate among inanimate entities and be at your fullest: you had to wait for the world; you had to write and wait and take on names in this choreography. I agreed to live among the things I put to use and saw where I went still around them. I said it in a poem. I said it in a drawing. I said it in the shirt I wore. I could tell the difference. I knew when it was an ancient entity and when it was new construction. I waited for the iron to ring. I hit the tuning fork against the clay pot. I called out "pen, pen, brush, pencil, pen" as I moved my eyes across my desk. The months never passed fast enough: you crept out after dark to walk the driveway. I came back in and said "eraser"—I'd forgotten it. I said "paper, paper, wood, table, wood." I said, "pigment, metal, metal, metal." Nothing moved. I sat at the long expanse and said, "hot, hot, warm, hot" and needed something cooling. Blueberries were objects. They sat in the ancient entity. I said, "bowl." I said, "bowls" and "cupboard." It was getting late. The wine had been chilling. I said the syntax of the thing: "Let's pour the wine in the glass"; "Let's put the plates on the table."

These were wares. This was their use. Yet emptying a glass of the wine it held brought the glass no closer to me than did my saying "glass" or having a thirst for the wine in the first place. We were glowing dark inanimates, straining on our respective stages, and this was grammar. This was what was left of being gathered. This was attention and consumption. This was the back of, the through, the still. This was what curved, what rimmed and covered. The glaze made me glow and become very slightly amethyst in color and begin to see other things go amethyst around me. I saw amethyst in the line between the town and the door, amethyst around the windows, on the lampshades, coating the filaments, amethyst on the stairs leading to the loft, amethyst in the vessel by the bed, in lying down to rest, in counting mornings.

An Epistolary Taxonomy of Holes
by Mia You

This thing is multiform, contingent, ambivalent and I call her my sex. Even if I make choices I still like everything. I like myself and you, but the hole we share accuses us both. I'll call it autofiction; on its head it accuses the world.

Kay Gabriel, "You Say Wife" (2022)

0*: Is when or where I start or you even fair?*

Dear Stranger,

I pull open the cover and meet you on the first page of Bernadette Mayer's *Sonnets*. This page is a facsimile of the poem "Birthday Sonnet for Grace." The poem appears to have been written on a typewriter, with its lines compressed tightly together. Remember when it mattered (to all of us, not just the type- and assignment-setters) how many letters we could fit onto a page, how many actual sheets of paper our writing would take up? The world was finite, and so through what spaces, what holes, could our writing fit into it? Sometimes we typed and then handwrote more into the margins. Often we typed onto the backs of sheets of paper we'd or others had already typed over. Our texts were siblings, co-tenants, and conspirators. They bled into each other. We didn't write recklessly, indulgently, noncommittally into endlessly self-generating rectangles that made everything seem both spontaneous and polished. We wrote recklessly, indulgently, noncommittally so that everyone could see how much work went into it.

No, dear Stranger, I don't remember this myself. The typewriter was already outdated by the time I wrote in any language. And besides, you are a stranger, how can I guess what you would remember? You might have been born in this century, never known a world that wasn't infinite and digital. You might not write. You might not even be a person. Do you know if I'm a person? I have a hole in my memory, or rather my memory is a hole that we can share if I dig it deep enough. When I look up "memory hole" I'm instructed to "see also:" / dev/null. Ash heap of history. Bit bucket. Blue wall of silence. Burn bag. *Damnatio memoriae*. Groupthink. Pact of forgetting. Propaganda. Retcon. Historical revisionism. Right to be forgotten. Social control. Spiral of silence. Censorship of images in the Soviet Union.

The only case study is historical. The rest could be the titles of heavy metal albums I wouldn't listen to but whose covers I'd admire. The past tense is most interesting when it's the past subjunctive, but the past subjunctive is the tense of passive aggression. I want a memory hole that brings us into the future. To ask, "Remember?" is a prompt to proceed. I pulled you in by writing about "you," then "us," then "we." But did you agree? And even if you didn't, do you still accept the invitation?

1: *Whaddya mean perforce?*

Dear Stranger,

The sonnet is the poetic form most closely associated with the modern lyric: intimate, expressive, an "I" addressing a "you," brief. The historical popularity of love sonnets essentially has turned the form into a post-it left on the counter: "Remember that I love you!" Even Mayer's "unweildy" [sic] "Birthday Sonnet for Grace" concludes: "I propose / To reiterate how I love you any time."

According to Helen Vendler, "a lyric is a role offered to a reader; the reader is to be the voice." In other words, the reader should see themselves as the writer of that post-it. Jonathan Culler, however, argues that the lyric positions the reader to be its recipient: "will you be as I describe you when I invoke you? will you be what I say you are?" But frankly, when I read most love sonnets, I identify as neither the lover nor the beloved but revert to the lurking third party implied by John Stuart Mill's formulation that "poetry is *overheard*." I'm somehow the one who has ended up listening in, despite "the poet's utter unconsciousness of a listener."

Mayer's sonnets fascinate me, however, because I'm never sure if she's offering no role at all, or any and all of them at once. I might just be listening in, but I'm also part of the scene. "C'mere / Tell me the rest of it," she writes in "Sonnet We Are Ordinary C'mere." *Tell me all about yourself*. But also: *tell me how the rest of this poem should go*. Not: *Who would you have been?* but: "What will you be?"

So what about you, dear Stranger? Will you be the lover, the beloved, or the lurker? Does it bother you that I've called you out? Does it trouble you that the poet's solitude has always been a performance?

2: *Will I write poetry?*

Sonnet Of Tasks That Feel Far More Pressing Right Now Than Writing This Poem Because It Would Be Upsetting If I Didn't Do Them But Most Likely No One Will Ever Remember I Did

1. Pack the children's lunches
2. Clean out the cat litter
3. Walk the dog
4. Vacuum the animal hair off the sofa
5. Answer an email about a course that I won't teach for another two years but the university administrators need on record *right now* what the assessments will be
6. Give a two-hour lecture on Sylvia Plath to a group of 120 first-year students forced to be in this class to fulfill their curriculum requirements. Note to self that I'm not even the one who put Plath on the course manual, why is this my job? Lead two additional two-hour seminars on Plath to a subset of this group of (progressively hostile) first-year students because the university administrators insist students are entitled to six "contact" hours each week for every course, although it's pretty clear that no one actually involved in this scenario wants so much contact
7. Deflect requests from students asking if they can send drafts of parts of their essays for feedback in advance of submitting the essays for a grade (and more feedback). No one really wants so much contact
8. Unclog the shower drain
9. Call to refill and then pick up my medication
10. Pick up my daughter from art class
11. Send periodic WhatsApp messages to my spouse who is away on a work trip for two weeks, just so he knows we're still alive, the children are not left locked inside a dark house by themselves (except for a few hours at a time), the animals are being fed, I'm totally fine, we're all managing, it's no problem at all, enjoy the trip
12. Feed all the animals, including myself
13. Wash and hang the underwear

(Then write this poem, because it will be upsetting if I don't do it, but most likely no one will ever remember I did)

3: *Is poetry's method of conclusion disjointed to for instance the life of a bee?*

Dear Stranger,

Do you read my sonnet as a complaint? I can already hear a voice (yours?) telling me, "But you don't know how privileged you are." Yes, I chose to have children, I chose to have pets, I chose to be married, I chose to work in the university. I *got* to choose, and choices come with responsibility. It's the "sourball of every revolution," as Mierle Laderman Ukeles writes in her manifesto for Maintenance Art: "after the revolution, who's going to pick up the garbage on Monday morning?"

I won't even claim my sonnet is about gendered labor. I chose to include tasks plenty of men do as well. Does that surprise you, Stranger? In "Gender as Accumulation Strategy," Kay Gabriel argues that "the forms of gendered exploitation and dispossession cannot be captured by reference solely—liberally—to the distinction between women and men, or for that matter cis- and trans identity." But, okay, okay, you're also right, maybe the sonnet *is* about gendered labor – in the sense that capital makes *all* of us female, until we accumulate enough of it so that we can coerce someone else into being female for us.

Does this offend you, Stranger? Do you identify as male anyway? Or do you identify as female but not in the way I'm talking about? My gender is exhausted, as the internet would say.

The problem is that the logic of capital encourages us – in fact grooms us – to want and want and want but has impoverished our capacity to comprehend and manage what we end up having. It presents us a world that is infinite, but what it hands us is so very finite.

In *Eros the Bittersweet*, Anne Carson writes, "If we follow the trajectory of eros we consistently find it tracing out this same route: it moves out from the lover toward the beloved, then ricochets back to the lover himself and the hole in him, unnoticed before. Who is the real subject of most love poems? Not the beloved. It is that hole." Not even the lover himself is the subject of the love poem. And now, as Mayer describes, we're "working so much in an owned world for rent money / Where there seems little time for the ancient hilarity." That ancient hilarity being love poetry.

Who is the real subject of the work that fills my days? Not the worker, nor the work. Not the caregiver, nor the cared-for. Not the desirer, nor the desired. *It is that hole.*

The hole doesn't complain.

4: Did you eat?

Dear Stranger,

For Mayer, the sonnet form is less an homage to any poetic forefathers – such as Petrarch, Shakespeare, or even Barrett Browning – than to the feminized body, encounters in shared spaces, and ambivalence.

In the *Teachers and Writers Handbook of Poetic Forms*, Mayer suggests, "Besides writing about love, you can write sonnets about things that happen when you're walking down the street or any thing or idea you want to describe (octave), and then, what you think of that (sestet)." In her note to *Sonnets*, she describes her own "headlong sonnets," the "Skinny Sonnets," as "a way of thinking amidst our hemispheric faults – put on what you call what a woman wears around her waist, our many-colored octave, then rest from thought and formulate the next design."

So then, dear Stranger, what are the pleasures of (chosen) constriction?

Only then, dear Stranger, what are the pleasures and possibilities of release?

5: What are you wearing? 6: Why aren't you here? 7: Where'd you put the window?

Dear Stranger,

To say that a sonnet is composed of an octave and a sestet is to say that a turn, or a *volta*, happens in between. Mayer often marks that customary *volta* through a stanza break – an empty white line, a "rest from thought," a hole marked out below writing's waist – just as she does following the eighth line of "Birthday Sonnet for Grace." But a number of other crucial turning points occur that might be read as being the poem's *voltas* (plural), troubling the idea that there is a singular, central one.

The obvious example is the sudden appearance of sets of rhyming lines following the poem's sixth line. The more significant shift, however, happens in the fourth line, when the "I" of the poem goes from addressing their beloved in third person, "Grace," to second person, "you." Are "Grace" and "you" the same figure? The parenthetical "(your)" preceding "Grace" in the first line doesn't entirely clarify. Why doesn't Mayer just write "(you)?" The possessive pronoun in fact suggests that "Grace" *belongs* to "you" but is not exactly, entirely "you." Mayer might mean "Your Grace," a hat tip to the deferential positioning of the beloved as nobility (often they *were* nobility, of course) in sonnets of yore, but Mayer quickly drops this deference. Ultimately, "you" gets subsumed into a "we" that also works hard for rent money.

We could say that Mayer's mode of address, just like the organizational structure of her sonnet, is inconsistent – or rather, that it is indeterminate, pluralistic. How many figures are actually in this sonnet? How many voltas? Is it ever possible to know for sure?

Juliana Spahr notes, "Mayer realizes that breaking conventional sexuality's limitations means bombing to widen the hole of desire and also doing the same to forms."

Or, as Stacy Doris writes in *Knot*, "Form means we keep changing our minds, at every velocity, due to life; poetry is that fact's lucidity."

8: *Do you think cocks are friendless?*

Dear Stranger,

I first met Doris' quote in Lisa Robertson's *Nilling*, which includes an essay describing "a small oval hole about the size and shape of my thumbnail" that appears in the vellum of a ninth-century codex of Lucretius' *De rerum natura*. Robertson notices "a faint drawing that added a labial ornamental border around the shape;" "the scribe had decorated the flaw in the skin with this mildly and endearingly erotic doodle."

Dear Stranger, do you know how many holes are in your body? To be honest I hadn't really tried to count before, and once I began, I quickly became confused about how exactly I should define one. Would the penis be considered a hole? If so, should nipples be counted as well? What about formerly-open holes or formed-to-open holes (is a bellybutton a hole)? How deep does a hole have to be? In "The Applicant," Sylvia Plath writes, "It works, there is nothing wrong with it. / You have a hole, it's a poultice. / You have an eye, it's an image."

Aren't pores technically also holes, just very small ones?

I decided to enter my question into a search engine. The internet also couldn't give me a conclusive answer. The most frequent answers for holes in the human body circled somewhere around 7, 8, or 9, although some went higher, and others went lower.

I suddenly recalled what Kim Hyesoon once said about her poem, "Manhole Humanity." Do you remember as well? "While writing that poem, I thought that all the holes of human beings were connected—our backsides with sewers and manholes, our noses and mouths with virus-filled air, and our eyes and ears with polluted air and noise. People in this world are divided vertically and separated sideways according to the color of their skin and ethnicity, among other things. Yet, the pipes beneath our anuses are all connected as one." Can you remember now? Maybe it would ring a bell if you heard it in the original language.

In any case, dear Stranger, I don't know you, you might be a person ("Grace"), you might be a concept (also "Grace"), or you might be a synecdoche ("Your Grace"). But even if you will say you have 0, I will say that's still a hole, holes are what we have in common. Just as Plath continues: "My boy, it's your last resort."

9: If we can't get along then who the fuck can?

Dear Stranger,

Remember how in the sonnet "14 Questions for Tom Savage," Mayer asks, "Age three, me you or saintly, supernal this's & that's of all the sexes, who is welcome in this world?"

That's a good question. Who is really welcome in this world?

Maybe none of us –

not me, not you,
not the *other* you

who's creeping around and eavesdropping
on what I'm saying –

but still in this unwieldy utopia,
still in this small space of writing –

maybe with some turning and taping
and tweaking and typing over –

we'll finally remember a way
for all of us to fit.

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Nine: Saturday

by Erin Adamo

There is a famous story about a man who ate his own children. Perhaps there are many such stories, but you must know the old one. In the old story, the man is a god, but he seems to have the wrong kinds of power for the era in which he finds himself. He has a wife, who provides him with offspring, and after each birth he ingests the infant like a sandwich: eyes hideously open, pupils turned back in his head; mouth vastly empty, filled with blackness.

(Obviously, here I am influenced by Goya.)

In at least one version of the story of this immortal nightmare father, the children he swallows remain alive inside his belly. When he is overthrown by the youngest child (who has been switched out for a rock during snack time), the previously devoured emerge from his stomach like passengers from a bus. They are adult gods, variously gifted. These are the deities of the modernity of the classical era. They bring to a close the archaic preclassical time—those eons of cannibalism, the patriarch's heinous jealousy, his weird pregnancy. The new gods bring about new politics; the family is no longer the sole governing body within the human sphere. We like, now, I think, to believe that the rescued gods are our gods, too. They seem to approve of capitalism and perhaps they even invented it. According to them, consumption of other people's children is preferable to consumption of one's own.

The ancient child-eater was a Greek god or a pre-god. Possibly he was an ancient deity of Asia Minor, a creator of worlds. The Greeks cast him as a madman, a self-defeating slayer of the future, a delay. The Greeks' magic is, I think, the closest to our own, and I have often wondered why they saw this Titan as a stop on the road to civilization, a sovereign deity but from a time no longer actual. I don't think that they were wrong. It's just that I don't see the cannibal as a creature of the past. He seems to me a fixture of empire, a familiar and gigantic dad, always hovering.

The Romans, in their way, recuperated him. Their god Saturn, from whom we have the name of the seventh day of the week, bore some of the old god's legends, quirks, and qualities. Saturn was a dissolver as well as a begetter. He presided over the changing of the year. His consorts were Lua Mater, goddess of the loosening of bonds, and Ops, associated with wealth, both of whom had beautiful names and were obviously fantastic lovers.

It's the Greek doubt, by the way, that I identify with—what I perceive as their herb-tinted melancholy, their respect for dust and slaughter. It's why I'm trying to claim them for us, in spite of the far more obvious parallels between the Roman Empire and America.

I grew up in the United States and of course we have our new gods, too. The problem is that we haven't bothered to name any of them and meanwhile go around worshipping some principle, even as the gods are present and continue to demand sacrifices of us. We have kinetic images we call cartoons. On Saturday morning, children all across the land drug themselves with fructose- and glucose-infused dairy (and/or dairy substitute) and lounge before a screen, upon which humanoid animals and animated inanimate objects struggle and love. Violent deaths are part of the repertoire, as are scenes of seduction. Sometimes the characters encounter a witch or other hermit-like, self-taught chef, someone who would like very much to eat them. A child could find herself imploring the moving fields of color on the screen, "Don't go in there!" It is meant to be fun and funny, but, as all projections do, these scenarios contain lessons.

I sat there, as a child, and I am not sure what I learned. Could I even truly feel the moments when, watching, I was transmogrified into a dancing cow, for example, or a female cat pursued by an amorous skunk? I know that there was dread in these brief plays. There was joy, too, but the joy was fragile and entirely without permanence (if not mixed with awful cunning). "I love you," I whispered to the gray rabbit, as he bent his tall frame over a fence or leaned against a shed. *Life is everywhere*, silently I prayed, knowing this animal's powers of self-transformation, the certainty of his success, his ageless elastic ubiquity. All things were living. All things

contained the secret music of the world, its possibility; the objects, winds, waters, and animals. Vast, intricately informed hours rolled through my extremely young life. I watched. The brain strained atop its stem; it became a smooth-walled theater.

Meanwhile, my parents had discovered neighbors who resembled them. These were a man and a woman who were married with a single daughter. There was also a divorced man with two children who relentlessly pursued my parents' friendship. I want to talk about them.

It is terrible to talk about them, too. The couple with the only daughter, the Lerners, were intelligent and rich. My parents felt that they deserved the Lerners' friendship. The Lerners' daughter, Caroline, was older than I was. In fact, she *is* older than I am now, of course, since she is still alive. She has never married and has no children. One weekend, several years ago, I was invited by her mother to the building she and Mr. Lerner, Richard, had owned together. By this time Mr. Lerner, Richard, was deceased. I went to eat with Caroline and Caroline's mother, Mrs. Lerner, who was also named Caroline and must therefore be referred to as Caroline 1. Caroline 2, my supposed peer, was meanwhile very nice but had lately developed a tendency to not look me directly in the eyes when we spoke. I got the sense that Caroline 2 had been informed by Caroline 1 that I was a career woman, due to my apparently stable office position. What I did was either shameful or intimidating, perhaps a mix. Caroline 2 had begun adulthood as a software engineer on the West Coast, but had abandoned this life in her early thirties when her boyfriend, a presumed husband, pronounced her ultimately uncompelling. Caroline 2 returned to New York City where she took odd jobs, abandoning IT. Her existence was largely subsidized by her parents and she seemed to have determined never to date again. She was over forty but looked much younger, particularly after her father's passing. I have puzzled over the case of Caroline 2 for some time.

I can't imagine Caroline 2 found it comforting or delightful to be handed taxi fare by her mother at the end of the night, but perhaps

I am wrong. I can't imagine Caroline 2 liked living alone and waitressing. I can't imagine why Caroline 2 put Caroline 1 at the center of her perfectly good life but, then again, this was happening. Caroline 2 dwelled in a deep margin if not a pit.

Most of what I knew about Caroline 2 came, by the way, from the mouth of my own mother. Even as I observed Caroline 2 with fascination, I could not bring myself to form an alliance with her. Perhaps this was because I, in turn, understood that everything that Caroline 2 knew about me came from the mouth of her mother. We looked at each other from across a very long view. We grimaced and mimed. We liked to talk as little as possible, to be in the same room, if possible, not at all.

The last time I saw Caroline 1 and Caroline 2 was at the residence of Caroline 1, for that dinner. As I walked up the stairs of their narrow building where the kitchen was for some reason on the third floor, I considered, as I always did, Caroline 2's position. She was bound to inherit. Was her lack of a separate existence from that of her mother therefore a form of preemptive penitence for unearned wealth? Or, perhaps Caroline 2's renunciation wasn't even the result of personal feeling: Maybe Caroline 1 required it. Maybe it was a simple exchange.

Richard, husband and father, had died in a velvet armchair in one of these rooms. He was, to my mind, the only bearable person associated with the Lerner enterprise, but he may also have been a pathological liar, if not a career criminal; I just don't know. Richard was a short man, extremely charming. He had that premodern habit of being always very drunk or very high, but seeming sober. He smoked cigars among other things and carried a distinguished scent, was forever tanned and twinkling vaguely. I looked to him for avuncular advice, even as that impulse that had rendered me demented since the age of thirteen led me to try, perfunctorily, to sleep with him.

About that impulse: I know this is something I have so far left out. I've always been like this: by turns manic and catatonic. Of course, perhaps you've seen it anyway; I don't know. It has defined

my life, even as I have tried to escape it. I've tried, too, to think about the way it feels. In simple terms, it occurs to me as a vague hope for love—that someone will love me. Yet, in practice, particularly in the earliest time of its onset, it expressed itself via off-color remarks at dinner parties and weddings, etc., short skirts and carefully applied makeup, the cunning deployment of my vivid face. I was thirteen when I did what my mother would have considered unspeakable things, things I somehow felt compelled to experience: the apartment with that boy whose parents were never home and whose friends seemed to make their own money. The wall above the bed spray-painted in a crimped-seeming checkerboard pattern. The incompleteness of the place. I wonder even now if our acts live with us forever.

My mother's hatred of me prevented me from enjoying my unusual teenage beauty. I was not thin (a point my mother strove to keep foremost in my mind), but I was shapely and, given what I vaguely understood as my father's paternal Middle Eastern heritage, exotic, apparently. An acquaintance asked my mother once, indicating me, "How did she get so *exotic*?"

"She is not *exotic*," my mother replied.

"Mom," I wanted to know, "why did [X] say that I am exotic?"

"She was just trying to find something to say," my mother told me coldly. "[X's daughter] is so plain."

My mother was, at best, I think, unfriendly. However, I knew how to make her laugh, and it was this ability that made it possible for us to be in each other's presence.

My mother, of course, recognized the impulse. She said almost nothing to me about it. If ever I used the noun *sex* or adjective *sexy* she would become enraged and warn me, speaking in stiff bursts, about "your language." It was not, she seemed to intimate, that I was bound for hell but, rather, that I was disgusting, and no man wants a disgusting woman. I was likely, because of this, to be poor.

My disgustingness was, fortunately or unfortunately, a facet of myself I seemed helpless not to pursue. I pursued it variously: I kissed and felt up my female friends, slept with people whose names I did

not know, maintained a catalogue of conquests that attained three digits by the time I finished high school.

I'm sorry that I haven't said anything about this until now. I've tried to admit it, but I haven't known how. It somehow doesn't fit with everything else I know about myself. I suppose Richard makes me remember, in a way. I wanted him to take me far, far away. When we spoke he sometimes discovered a complex and distant region in his mind, and I enjoyed having a look at it with him. Also, my father adored Richard, and this was unusual, because my father hated everyone.

"Richard!" Caroline 1 would scream from the kitchen.

But there was an earlier time, a time that I recall, when I suppose it might have seemed possible and desirable to help me. In this time, when I was ten years old, Caroline 2 chatted amiably. Caroline 1 and Richard offered me a gift of a ribbon-festooned sweatshirt printed with the image of an enlarged playing card, the queen of hearts. I could be encouraged, even if the sick winter between my parents was difficult to be around.

Later, all things changed. No one paid any attention to my parents and the sickness was with me.

While I was still on my campaign to get information out of Barbara, I mentioned them, the Lerners. I wanted to hear what she might say.

Barbara said, "The daughter is damaged."

"*The*," she'd said. I asked Barbara what she meant.

"I've seen her and I can tell. She is damaged. Damaged goods."

Barbara's manner did not invite further inquiry.

Of course, I had my ideas: from television and movies and literature. When a child is said to be "damaged" it is because someone (usually in her family) has hurt her.

But here something else is coming back. I'm remembering that at our lunch, our summit, Barbara told me about herself. She wouldn't speak to me about her children, not Elliott nor Mags, nor what has befallen them; however, she would discuss herself. At the end of our conversation, I must have said something about my mother, about

how I did not understand why she did not leave my father. I must have seemed annoyed and dismissive. Maybe I was.

Barbara was at pains to let me know that I did not understand the situation. And the "situation," as far as Barbara was concerned, was that of women, the situation *for* women, which was historical.

Barbara said, "Did you know I was raped two times?"

It had happened, she told me, once in Paris and once in a basement in Manhattan. Each time the man was someone she had met on several occasions before. In Paris, he returned to the apartment he was renting her because, of course, he had the key. In New York, it was after a rehearsal, when the others had left.

"You don't understand," Barbara told me. She meant that my mother's choice to remain with my father was not all that unreasonable. "You have to forgive her."

But even in my rage I was unsure what for.

About that other family: I believe they were people we met one day when I was about ten. There was a daughter who was my age. I played with her. Also, there was an older son. The father was divorced from his first wife and had begun dating a woman who was an artist. The artist was an artist without a major career and so she was a good parent to his children. Let us say their last name was Hell, the German word for "bright," "light," or "pale." There was Abbey Hell and Josh Hell and their father, Mark Hell. And there was the artist, whose name was Laynie. (Laynie, by the way, came up very briefly earlier. It was her ass that Barbara saw my father grabbing, during that summer of the house rental and Barbara and Palmer's penury.)

Mark Hell was lanky. He was largely bald, with a few vain wisps. I recall him often in shorts, New Balances. He was a math addict, someone known to cheat at tennis. Boundaries were fungible. He worked for a powerful NGO.

My parents mocked Mark Hell, PhD. They made fun of his predictable nine a.m. phone calls, his answering-machine messages including his full name. At the same time, they went wherever he told them to go. Mark Hell extolled my mother's beauty. It was

strange to see. My father was a handsome man from working-class origins whose looks and photographic memory had taken him places in the early 1960s. Now he seemed to prefer, whenever possible, not to use language at all. Mark Hell, on the other hand, spoke constantly. He filled rooms and slayed hours with his perfectly waxed sentences on the impossibility of fossil fuel regulation, the boon of developing economies, the state of certain currencies he and his colleagues hoped to stabilize through austerity. He was always going to Brussels to give another talk. He commanded the dinner party to stare at my mother. He told me that I should really consider marrying Josh, who obviously preferred men and would remain closeted well into his thirties. "Grab him!" exclaimed Mark Hell, clutching, as usual, at social straws. Mark Hell did not care that he did not understand his offspring. This wasn't important to him. Nor was it important that they would run away from him to other continents as soon as legally and financially feasible. Mark Hell pleaded with Laynie to live with him. He pleaded with Laynie to marry him. He cheated on her religiously.

He was a narcissist with an ambiguous interest in humiliation.

So I never liked Mark Hell. Given his behavior, this is probably not surprising, but all the same, there were plenty of people I knew and loved who did awful stuff, and I wonder, to this day, even, why I found him so uniquely worthy of censure. Dr. Hell was tall and thin and ugly, it was true. I was, by the standards of the end of the previous century, overweight, but I, like everyone else I have named, including Laynie, was pretty cute. Mark Hell controlled all of us, in part because he was an outsider to an in-group we didn't even know we had. We didn't realize that Mark Hell was busy collecting us. He had, after all, collected his own children, which is an odd thing to do. He took us on outings and displayed his collection to the world. My mother, he said, was beautiful. Probably he sometimes slept with her. Dr. Hell was an expert, above all, in revenge. He was an economist.

One time something strange happened. I must have been about twelve years old. We were on Long Island, walking on a beach near the cottage where Laynie had lived, largely alone, until she met

Dr. Hell. It was a cool late spring, fog hanging over the sand. We walked slowly in our collected group.

We needed something to do. It was a turbulent day, variously located; the water too cold, even for feet.

I was carrying with me a small, beaded coin purse, something I had found the previous summer in a secondhand store and purchased using my allowance. I recall it as mostly white, with pink and red and green and yellow, a shimmering flower pattern. I don't remember what I had inside. Maybe there was a folded dollar bill in there and a pebble. I must have been shifting the purse from pocket to pocket in my jeans, which were also secondhand and too tight for me, as was all of my clothing at this time. I moved it around as a way of seeking comfort. I do remember this. And I scanned the ground. Although I could not have told you this at the time, there was something that I was attempting to avoid the feeling of.

Somewhere I dropped the purse. Or perhaps the tightness of my pants forced it out, I don't know.

What I can recall is that I could not be consoled. Not for the rest of that day, nor for the next. I could not tear my mind away from the notion that this object was irrevocably gone. We spent an hour searching for the purse on the beach, retracing our steps, until my mother started screaming that she had wasted enough time already and that if I had wanted to keep something I should have held on to it.

I remember Dr. Hell as the most meticulous searcher. His voice was strangely calm, his logistical interrogations keen. He seemed to like the thought of walking backward. To him, a loss was something to be savored.

ANALYSIS II

For the following questions, select the best answer. You may not select more than one answer. Responses including more than one answer will be marked as incorrect. Incorrect or unanswered questions receive, as before and for all foreseeable time to come, a score of minus one.

The narrator summarizes the myth of Cronos, aka Saturn, on pages 115–16. This citation most likely conveys which of the following meanings:

a. Male aggression and violence are mostly condoned within modern societies.
b. Women often behave in such a way as to enable male aggression and violence.
c. We should reconsider the historical significance of the name of the day of the week, Saturday.
d. Some things cannot be discussed.
e. A and b.
f. B and d.

The two families, the Lerners and the Hells, have what in common?

a. In both families, a father has a dominant role.
b. In both families, a daughter becomes a close confidant of the narrator.
c. The narrator is very interested in the actions of the fathers in both families. Specifically, she is interested in whether the fathers are faithful to their wives.
d. These two families have nothing in common.
e. None of the above.

We can assume that:

a. The narrator is telling us everything she knows.
b. The narrator is telling us everything that she thinks she knows.
c. What the narrator tells us is an approximation of reality designed to shield the narrator from overwhelming sensations, i.e., the Truth.
d. Because all of the answers listed so far amount to the same thing, all of the above.
e. Each of these answers is distinct and unique. So, not d, even if d is extremely tempting.
f. Experience has a fundamental reality, separate from descriptions of it. This reality can really be touched upon in language, no matter what the philosophers say.
g. There is no answer.

We can assume that:

a. The narrator is a version of the author who has traveled into the future.
b. The author is a time traveler.
c. Both a and b.
d. What should have been, is.

Exposure in relation to performance
by Pia Louwerens

pages 101–102

Epistemology of the Closet – paranoia – performing or reading – inwards or outwards – hosting – being hosted – writing the performance for the event with S. – observing the bookshelf in the library closely – the materials – my living room with the shag carpet –

I'm pacing through my ten square metre apartment, five square metres of which are covered by a shag rug that reminds everyone of spaghetti bolognese. There are only eighteen minutes left to write. I'm thirsty. I have retracted fully into myself, into the space where there are very few experiences, and I'm trying to force myself to project myself, to put myself in my own shoes in the library space of the institution. There are people watching. On the shelves are books, some of them showcased. It's a book exhibition, but I'm not sure why. I feel like retreating into reading, into the text. To be silent, absorbed into the closet.

I imagine closing my eyes and touching the table of the institution, the one where I spend all my time. It's large, smooth. It's cold. It's probably wood but it might be plastic for all I care. It's too cold in the concrete maze, but when the heating is on the air turns stuffy and my eyeballs dry out. I'm learning to turn on the heating by myself. I have to walk down the stairs, open a lock with a four-digit access code and then go past a slab of wood into a canteen that's no longer in use. Past the tables and chairs, there is a wall and around that corner is the heating board. I can't be there officially, because if a fire breaks out there's no place to flee.

I imagine performing the script I'm writing, in the library, standing next to the bookcase. There's still a lot of empty space here, ready for more books. Perhaps I can lean on it a bit, shape my body accordingly.

> What will happen when I become truly embedded? Sedgwick criticises the binary opposition of inside and outside when writing about the epistemology of the closet. A theorist writing about Sedgwick says that 'refusing to reveal one's sexuality is as much a performative act as revealing it, since "*closetedness* itself is a performance initiated by the speech act of silence."'

Later, at the institution, I tell the curator that perhaps we don't have to meet every week. Although I enjoy our conversations, they make me feel a bit nervous, as if I'm being checked on. The curator smiles mysteriously and says: 'Well, we should talk about that next time.'

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...have ...word reading group

rile* books

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